More certain than the age of the Shivratri festival are the much older references to the sacred geography of the region in Vedic texts, the Ramayana and the Mahabharata. The Pandavas apparently began their last, concealed year of exile in a forest nearby. The Vindhya Range, where Khajuraho lies, was once the southern extent of Aryavarta, marking north and south Indian cultures. To its south, the dominant Indo-Aryan cultural elites of the north imagined forests sheltering Mleccha tribes, rakshasas and fierce deities like Kali. Also ancient is Shiva's presence in the region. While Shiva's origins remain contested, he's clearly a composite god with features of many indigenous folk deities, one of whom may well have been from the Vindhyas. He retains many non-Aryan attributes, such as being a dark-skinned forest dweller, a healer, lord of animals (*pashupati*), a dancer and player of drums, wearing long matted hair, tiger skin and a garland of snakes. The Shiva that emerged later had these and additional attributes, such as a Himalayan abode, a third eye, the powers of a creative destroyer and much more. As with the Buddha, Brahminical Hinduism later appropriated both Shiva and Kali.

The forests mentioned in the legends are long gone. My train from Jhansi to Khajuraho went across an arid scrubland broken up by irrigated farmland and village homes. Pastoralists abounded, raising goats, cattle and chickens. I saw green fields with crops of lentils, wheat, mustard and sugarcane, fed almost entirely by groundwater. The region's chronically low land productivity has been worsened in recent years by erratic rainfall and droughts, raising poverty rates and driving more of the young villagers to big cities.

The Rediscovery of Khajuraho

The first Britisher to stumble upon the ruined temples of Khajuraho and their sexually explicit sculptures was Captain T.S. Burt of Bengal Engineers. Burt was passing through the region in 1838. Intrigued by the stories he had heard about provocative ruins half-buried in the jungle, he got a few strong men to carry him in a palanquin for 44 kilometres to reach Khajuraho. A dense forest had long engulfed the temples. Pushing through the undergrowth, he was 'much delighted at the venerable, and picturesque